stored, new roads and sports stadiums have come up, but most importantly Gurez valley was opened up for tourists after a ceasefire agreement between the two armies in February 2021. This year, it has hosted more than 38,000 tourists, from 4,700 in 2021.

The B2V programme, according to the administration, is designed to 'reach out to the people at the grassroots level' and ensure 'equitable development' in the rural pockets of J&K. The weeklong camps, held between October 27 and November 3 this year, saw the participation of 1.5 million people and 25,000 government employees across all 4,291 panchayats under the UT (see *Rural Outreach*). The huge response, according to Rohit Kansal, principal secretary, information and higher education, J&K, has been spurred by radical changes ushered in by the first three editions, where grievances and demands were reportedly addressed in a fixed timeframe. This time, the programme was preceded by a preparatory '*Jan Abhiyan*' phase, held from October 15 to 26 to generate momentum with the help of 5,000 awareness and training camps.

An extensive follow-up mechanism has been ensured for timely disposal of grievances, Kansal tells INDIA TODAY. One of the officials who visits the village will be designated its *panchayat prabhari* (in-charge) and will return at least once every quarter to get feedback, he explains. This is to ensure accountability and perhaps counter the criticism from earlier B2V editions where there were incidents of no follow-up/redressal on registered complaints. The *prabhari* will be responsible for achievement of all deliverables, such as providing basic amenities, distribution of beneficiary cards and creation of avenues for self-employment. "All complaints and suggestions will be disposed of by local officials in two months. Policy decisions, if any, will be taken at the secretariat level over the next one year," says Kansal.

The J&K state assembly was dissolved on November 21, 2018, five months after the collapse of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) government. Since then, J&K has been ruled by the BJP-led Centre, which is banking on panchayats to empower 'grassroots democracy' in the re-ordered political set-up after August 5, 2019. Initially, when gram panchayats were set up in 2018—amid the election boycott by the National Conference (NC), PDP and Congress—people were sceptical as they were now helmed by independent and BJP members. But B2V has helped panchayats rebuild trust, ensuring that development reaches rural areas, say officials involved in the process.

J&K chief secretary Arun Kumar Mehta says transparency is the key element that has helped foster public trust and participation. People were allowed to speak openly about corruption and other issues at panchayat meetings and Mehta adds that the *Janbhagidari* web portal now allows them to oversee projects in their areas. "All things that are doable are being done. People need to believe us [when we say] there won't be middlemen anymore," he says.

THE 'BACK TO VILLAGE' PROGRAMME HAS HELPED THE PANCHAYATS REBUILD TRUST BY ENSURING THAT DEVELOPMENT REACHES THE RURAL POCKETS OF J&K, SAY OFFICIALS

That said, not everyone is sold on these claims of development. For instance, in Budgam's Summerbagh, villagers lament the shortage of funds for works in their village (B2V has an annual budget of Rs 10 lakh per panchayat). "Our ward has about 250 houses, and we are still awaiting proper sanitation facilities and a regular bus service," says Bilal Ahmad Sheikh, 42, an auto driver. All Jammu and Kashmir Panchayat Conference (AJKPC), an organisation of sarpanches and panches, is also unimpressed. President Anil Sharma, sarpanch of Jindra panchayat in Jammu and a BJP supporter himself, says even the works from the previous edition remain half done. In his own panchayat, a local road tendered for Rs 5 lakh from B2V's second edition is pending with only 500 metres completed so far against the total 1.5 km. "B2V is a positive initiative, but the programme should have been designed in consultation with panchayat representatives," he says. Sharma also pointed to a meeting that he and other sarpanches had last week with visiting local body representatives from Kerala, who apparently told them that the annual budget of many panchayats in the southern state was over Rs 10 crore, leaving the Valley representatives stunned. The annual budget for each panchayat in J&K is Rs 25 lakh, says Sharma.

Communist Party of India (Marxist) veteran Mohammad Yousuf Tarigami alleges that "not even a fraction" of the demands from the past three editions of B2V have been fulfilled. "The enthusiasm among people, in fact, has dipped this year," says the former MLA, who is also the spokesperson for the People's Alliance for Gupkar Declaration, the grouping of opposition parties that has been demanding restoration of J&K's special status and statehood.

Chief secretary Mehta, though, insists that "things are changing for the better". He claims that over 50,000 projects, big and small, were completed in J&K in 2021-22, compared to only 9,000 in 2018-2019. As proof of the changing situation, he points to the huge attendance at football matches conducted under floodlights in north Kashmir's Sopore, once a hotbed of militancy. "It shows that Kashmiris want to move on and lead normal lives," says Mehta. That people are out and about is, of course, a sign of 'normalcy', but questions must be asked whether this form of development can be a viable alternative to an elected, free, democratic government in Kashmir. ■